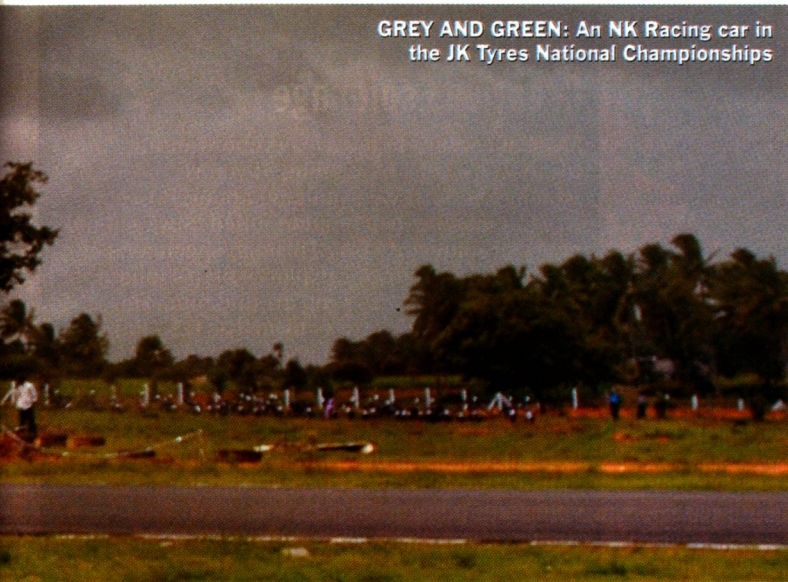


GREY AND GREEN: An NK Racing car in the JK Tyres National Championships



THE FORMULA ONE QUESTION

Karthikeyan's Choice

In Chettipalayam, Narain Karthikeyan was asked just one question. Would he take up The Offer? India's first Formula One driver, now a test driver for Williams, has been approached by F1 team Spyker to race for them in the season's last seven races. One of the lower-ranked teams on the F1 ladder, Spyker is familiar territory for Karthikeyan who raced with them in the 2005 season. Spyker is in fact the current incarnation of team Jordan, who signed Karthikeyan up for his F1 debut and for a brief period were also named Midland. Spyker have recently sacked their German driver Christijan Albers and indicated their interest in the Indian. Karthikeyan is yet to take a decision on whether to return to a struggling team or keep the security of working with Williams. However due to new FIA rules, the time test drivers get on cars has been severely cut back. Karthikeyan says, "My racing instincts say I want to drive. After my experience as a tester at Williams, I think I can extract more out of an F-1 car now than I could."

cars in the inaugural year to two and NK Racing estimates expenditure per car to touch Rs 10 lakh per season. Karthikeyan says, "The pressure to get the most out of two cars to get the wins is a lot more but management-wise two are much easier to handle".

Of their drivers from the first year, Akhil Khushlani now races in the Formula BMW Asia series. Talks are on with the Tata Racing School to set up an academy, the country's first proper racing institution, to run out of Chettipalayam three months at time.

The decision of India's most famous driver, and most famous racing "brand", to enter a team in the national championships should, you would imagine, be welcomed. But NK Racing faced some early sniping from envious opponents in season one.

It could be, says Setna, because the team was determined to look and act like professionals. The mechanics, who had worked on jeeps and trucks, were trained to work on race cars, split into specialist groups, like electricals and gearbox. Fitness regimes were drilled

into the rookies and they were given books on driving and engineering. The pit signage had to be smart, the team used walkie talkies, and occasionally, pit-to-car communication.

Most importantly, the drives were free. It was the team and not the driver who found the sponsor to pay racing charges. (Over a six-round season, drivers must cough up Rs 35,000 for a Swift, Rs 45,000 for the Hyundai and Rs 1 lakh for the Rolon per round.) For contenders from non-racing families, it was a break from heaven. Shelar's father Sanjay, a director in an engineering firm, says, "We have no tension about money, we don't have to run around for sponsorship."

As the race draws close, the pit gets calmer. The drivers are left to themselves, the engineers finish their job and leave it to the gods of the gearbox, and Karthikeyan heads off to watch. "Racing drivers... you need to treat them gently," he says and he knows because at heart he is still one. In a sport about technology, aerodynamics and big bucks, the most precious part of a race car is still the driver, for whom spares are not easily found.

Along with dozens of sponsors' stickers, NK Racing cars sport the words "Aditya B+ve" and "Saran B+ve". They read like inspirational rev-up slogans, but are actually the drivers' blood groups, mandatory on every race car. All race tracks must have an ambulance and a fire truck on standby.

On the weekend, nothing flammable catches fire, but Patel lights up. He finishes third in one race and wins the second, biding his time as two leaders engage in a charged skirmish. Before they have time to say, "Chettipalayam", Patel slips past them on the inside.

Every race is a sensory overload, a blur of metal and rubber, the howl of engines, the smell of gas but this is almost a cerebral performance. It comes from a skinny kid who looks like he belongs in the quietest corner of a library. His team is going mental; engineers leap up and down, applauding mechanics pour over the pit wall.

Patel roars past the finish line and Karthikeyan smiles. It is not the smile seen on hoardings or on tv but a sunbeam at full throttle. He says, "Inside me, I'm really, happy I did this." ■